

UNIVERSITY OF ESSEX

Undergraduate Examinations 2015

CURRENT DISPUTES IN SOCIOLOGY: SOCIOLOGICAL ANALYSIS III

Time allowed: **THREE** hours

Candidates are permitted to bring into the examination room paper dictionaries (with the title in English).

Candidates must answer **THREE** questions: **ONE** from **SECTION A**, **ONE** from **SECTION B** and **ONE** from **EITHER** Section.

The paper consists of **eighteen** questions in total: nine in each Section.

All questions are of equal weight.

Please do not leave your seat unless you are given permission by an invigilator. Do not communicate in any way with any other candidate in the examination room. Do not open the question paper until told to do so. All answers must be written in the answer book(s) provided. All rough work must be written in the answer book(s) provided. A line should be drawn through any rough work to indicate to the examiner that it is not part of the work to be marked. At the end of the examination, remain seated until your answer book(s) have been collected and you have been told you may leave.

Candidates must answer **THREE** questions: **ONE** from **SECTION A**, **ONE** from **SECTION B** and **ONE** from **EITHER** Section.

SECTION A

1. What does Foucault mean by the term “docile bodies”?
2. Critically assess Foucault’s distinctive version of the concept of “power”.
3. Outline and assess Bourdieu’s contribution to understanding contemporary social inequality.
4. Critically assess Roland Barthes’ semiological approach to analysing contemporary society?
5. To what extent is the concept of modernity still of interest to sociologists?
6. Do we live in a modern or postmodern society?
7. What do feminists mean when they suggest that we should think of knowledge as something which requires adopting a standpoint? How useful is this approach?
8. Can the concept of “women’s experience” provide us with genuine knowledge about the world?
9. Outline and assess how sociologists have tried to theorize global economic inequality.

END OF SECTION A

Candidates must answer **THREE** questions: **ONE** from **SECTION A**, **ONE** from **SECTION B** and **ONE** from **EITHER** Section.

SECTION B

10. “All sociological knowledge should be capable of being verified”. Critically assess this statement through a discussion of the status of empiricism.
11. How did the neo-Kantians critique the empiricist approach? How successful were they?
12. What is distinctive about a phenomenological approach to understanding the social world? How useful is this theoretical position?
13. Does Critical Realism succeed in outlining a coherent approach to analysing the social world?
14. Who gives the better account of how scientific knowledge is produced – Popper or Kuhn?
15. Outline and assess the key ways in which sociologists have tried to theorize the environment.
16. What did Said mean by the term “orientalism”? How useful is his concept for widening the scope of social theory. You should compare his work with the ideas of at least one other post-colonial theorist.
17. Outline and assess Du Bois’ description of the experience of being a “black soul”. How relevant are his ideas for thinking about “race”/ethnicity?
18. In what ways does Latour challenge traditional understandings of society and the social?

END OF SECTION B

END OF PAPER